Question 1 – Largest 20 startup incubators in India: methodology and ranking justification

Companion to `Q1_Incubator_Research.xlsx` (sheets: Top 20 Ranking, All Candidates (32), Method).

1. What "largest" means here

"Largest" is measured by **the number of startups an incubator has supported**. Funding raised by portfolio startups, revenue and floor space were considered and rejected: they are either not published or reported on incompatible bases (raised by startups vs. invested by the incubator vs. grants received by the incubator). Startup counts are the one figure almost every incubator publishes.

2. Search methodology (how candidates were found)

Two search routes were used and their results merged into one candidate pool of **32 organisations** (all listed in the All Candidates sheet).

Route	What it covers	Why it is used
A. Registries and directories	Government / ecosystem listings of recognised incubators and curated grant-provider directories	Authoritative coverage of recognised institutional incubators (university, government-backed, DST/NIDHI-type), including ones with little press coverage
B. Open web	Each incubator's own website, news coverage, press releases and company databases	Finds privately run accelerators missing from registries, and gives the most recent size figures (directory figures are often years old)

Using both routes reduces the bias of either alone: registries over-represent publicly funded institutions, while press coverage over-represents well-funded, well-publicised private programmes.

For every candidate the following were recorded: city, year founded, type, website, number of startups supported, funding information and the source of each figure.

3. Eligibility rule

An organisation is ranked only if it **runs its own incubation or acceleration programme for startups**. Two groups are excluded:

- **Investment funds and angel networks (6):** Peak XV Surge, 100X.VC, India Accelerator, GSF Accelerator, FAAD Network, AdvantEdge Founders. Their main activity is investing capital.

- **Funding schemes and umbrella networks (2):** BIRAC BioNEST, Atal Community Innovation Centres. They fund or network many separate centres; counting them would double-count those centres and compare a national scheme with a single incubator.

24 organisations are eligible. The decision for all 32 is in the All Candidates sheet.

4. Ranking methodology (two methodologies, then combined)

	Methodology 1 – Scale	**Methodology 2 – Throughput**
Measure	Cumulative startups supported	Startups per year = cumulative ÷ years operating
Question answered	Which incubators have supported the most startups in total?	Which incubators support startups at the fastest pace?
Why	Direct reading of "largest"	Stops old incubators winning on age alone and stops young ones being ignored

Combination. Each eligible incubator gets a rank on each method (1 = largest). The **final rank** is the rank of the **average of the two ranks**; a tie is broken by the better Methodology 1 rank. The 20 best final ranks are the Top 20. Everything is a live formula in the workbook (the only typed inputs are the startup figure and years operating).

5. Result

Final	Incubator	Startups (used)	Years	Per year	M1	M2
1	Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM)	8,000	20	400.0	1	1
2	NSRCEL (IIM Bangalore)	3,222	26	123.9	2	3
3	T-Hub	2,000	11	181.8	3	2
4	Zone Startups India	600	12	50.0	5	4
5	CIIE.CO (IIM Ahmedabad; now IIMA Ventures)	1,000	24	41.7	4	7
6	IIT Madras Incubation Cell (IITMIC)	567	13	43.6	7	5
7	Startup Village (Kochi)	570	14	40.7	6	8
8	WE Hub	342	8	42.8	9	6
9	a-IDEA (NAARM TBI)	300	12	25.0	11	10
10	Amrita TBI	320	21	15.2	10	13
11	Marwari Catalysts	200	7	28.6	14	9
12	TREC-STEP (Tiruchirappalli)	400	40	10.0	8	16
13	GUSEC	234	10	23.4	13	11
14	SINE (IIT Bombay)	245	22	11.1	12	15
15	Maker Village	194	11	17.6	15	12
16	JioGenNext	185	13	14.2	16	14
17	JSS ATEB STEP	150	27	5.6	17	18
18	IIM Calcutta Innovation Park (IIMCIP)	100	12	8.3	19	17
19	Amity Innovation Incubator	100	18	5.6	19	18
20	Agri-Business Incubator (ABI-ICRISAT)	118	23	5.1	18	20

Next in line (outside the Top 20): BITS Pilani TBI (21, 75 startups), Target Accelerator Program (22), Sathyabama TBI (23), thinQbate (24).

6. Why this Top 20 can be trusted

- **Robust to the choice of method.** Using Methodology 1 alone or Methodology 2 alone gives the **same 20 organisations**; only their order changes. Combining the two only settles the order.
- **Clear cut-off.** The 20th organisation has 118 startups (100 for the 18th–19th); the 21st has 75.
- **Sensitivity to the eligibility rule.** If investment funds were allowed in, Peak XV Surge, 100X.VC and FAAD Network would enter and displace IIMCIP, Amity Innovation Incubator and ABI-ICRISAT (ranks 18–20). The top 8 would be unchanged and the incubators ranked 9–17 would move down by at most three places. This is the main judgement call in the study.

7. Limitations

- **Self-reported, unaudited counts** with different definitions (registered, supported, accelerated, incubated). The Data note column in the workbook flags the weakest figures. KSUM's 8,000 is "registered startups" and is the most generous count in the list.
- **Figures from different dates (2021–2026).** Years operating is counted to 2026 for all, so incubators whose figure is old (WE Hub, Startup Village, Zone Startups) have their throughput understated.
- **Judgement calls.** KSUM (a state agency that runs incubation) is kept while ACIC (a scheme funding many centres) is excluded; Peak XV Surge is excluded as a VC-run programme. A different reasonable rule would change ranks 17–20.
- **Data correction.** The earlier research sheet showed KSUM with 10 years of operation although it lists 2006 as the founding year; 20 years is used here.

8. Reproducing the ranking

Open `Q1_Incubator_Research.xlsx` → Top 20 Ranking. Change a startup figure or years value (blue cells) and ranks recalculate. Rows are listed in the order of the current result; re-sort by column A after changing inputs.